

Transparency is the new fair play

In the age of lip-readers, zoom lenses and social media detectives, the covered mouth had become football's **last refuge** for privacy.

Suresh Menon

It is nearly two decades since France's Zinedine Zidane head-butted Marco Materazzi in a World Cup final that Italy won.

Materazzi had insulted either Zidane's mother or his sister, but the butting happened far from the action and no one saw what led up to it.

(As an aside, here's a description in a newspaper: "It looked like an excellent butt from a technical point of view: shoulders swivelling, neck wrenched, forehead rammed into the breast bone.")

In that final, there were 25 cameras at the stadium; at this year's World Cup there will likely be body cams for the referees, 3D shots of all the players so cameras can follow them, cameras for the VAR, and it will be difficult for players to slip in a goal by hand or get away with an offside.

But a well-disguised insult could still get through despite FIFA's rule that any player who covers his mouth when speaking to an opponent could be punished.

Real Madrid's Vinicius Junior alleged last month that he had been racially abused by Benfica's Gianluca Prestianni during a Champions League game. Prestianni concealed what he said by speaking behind his raised shirt. The 'Vinicius Rule' is aimed at reducing racist remarks, and to that extent will be welcomed.

Yet...

There is something charmingly human about players creating small cocoons in a stadium of noise. Amid 70,000 voices, two men sharing a private sentence is a reminder that football, for all its grandeur, is still a



All in the game: Real Madrid's Vinicius Junior alleged last month that he had been racially abused by Benfica's Gianluca Prestianni during a Champions League game. Prestianni concealed what he said by speaking behind his raised shirt. AFP

conversation.

In the age of lip-readers, zoom lenses and social media detectives, the covered mouth had become football's last refuge for privacy. A defender leaning into a striker, a captain negotiating with a referee, a manager relaying coded instructions via a substitute — these are small conspiracies in a game built on larger ones.

If players must argue, let them do so audibly, seems to be FIFA's attitude. If they must insult, let it catch the microphones. Secrecy, like time-wasting, is bad for business. Broadcasters who invest billions prefer drama to be out in the open. Transparency is the

new fair play. If you are going to say something controversial, kindly ensure it is available in high definition.

However, the game has always thrived on nuance. A midfielder shielding the ball knows that concealment is an art. Why deny him the same right with his words? When two opponents exchange pleasantries, some almost printable, they become part of the sport's folklore. The covered mouth is not always a sign of conspiracy; often it is courtesy. No one in the stands (or watching TV) needs a lip-reading tutorial in fruity vocabulary.

Administrators fear the unseen sentence as much as the unseen foul. So they regulate it.

Will it change the sport? Doubtful. Footballers are inventive. If they cannot hide behind a shirt, they will master the art of the sideways murmur. If they cannot shield their lips, they will let their eyes do the talking. The language of the game is richer and older than the rulebook.